FREIGHT UNIVERSITY LIBRARY

DRIVERS BEFORE TRUCKS

Learn the business. Build the driver pipeline.
Then buy the equipment.



A truck is a purchase. A trucking business is a responsibility.

DRIVERS BEFORE TRUCKS

The practical guide to learning the business, recruiting drivers, and buying equipment in the right order.

Michael Thomas
Founder, Freight University

Freight University Library | 2026 edition

freightuniversity.online

The images are original AI-generated illustrations of fictional people and situations. They don't depict actual customers, employees, trucks or business results.

Contents

How to use this book 4

Introduction: The call that comes too late 5

1. The equipment-first trap 6

2. Read the numbers honestly 10

3. Invest in knowledge first 13

4. The driver reality and the empty seat 17

5. Recruiting is a skill you never stop using 20

6. Write the real job 23

7. Paint your Bob Ross 26

8. Get found 29

9. Go where drivers are filling out applications 32

10. Put AI to work 36

11. Answer fast and track everybody 39

12. Screen carefully and make the first hire 42

13. Keep the pipeline alive 46

14. Make the purchase decision 50

Worksheet 1: The job you’re actually offering 54

Worksheet 2: Empty-seat cash budget 55

Worksheet 3: Weekly recruiting review 56

Worksheet 4: Qualification and dispatch release 57

Worksheet 5: Before you buy 58

Conclusion: Build the business before you buy the truck 59

Sources 60

How to use this book

Read this before you sign for a truck. If you already bought one, go to the end of Chapter 14 first, then come back and work through the rest.

Whether you're about to invest in equipment, already running a trucking company, or helping somebody build one, this book teaches you one skill above all: how to recruit drivers. That's what keeps the equipment moving. So the order is simple. Learn the business. Find out where the freight is. Figure out the job. Build your way of finding drivers. Then buy the truck. In real life some of it overlaps, because your insurance, your paperwork, your hire and your truck delivery all have to land together. But the big questions get answered before the big money gets spent.

This book is for small for-hire trucking companies running equipment that takes a CDL. If you're hauling hazmat or passengers, or running local non-CDL work, some of the rules are different. And when I say "non-CDL owner," I mean an owner who doesn't hold a CDL. The truck still needs a CDL driver.

Every dollar figure, recruiting budget and case in here is made up to teach with. Wes, Rosa, Sam and the drivers aren't real people. My own stories are real, and I'll tell you when it's me talking. None of it is an earnings promise, and none of it is legal, tax or insurance advice. Rules change. So check the current rule, and get your attorney, accountant and insurance agent on the things that are theirs to answer.

Introduction: The call that comes too late

I get these phone calls all the time. “Michael, I want to buy a truck. I want you to manage it. Can you do it?”

I can. Then I ask, “How about the driver?”

That’s when I hit the brakes.

Sometimes the truck’s already bought. It’s sitting there with a payment on it. Now the call is, “I bought a truck. Can you find me a driver?” That sounds like the last little item on a finished business plan. Most of the time it’s the first sign there never was one.

I know of somebody who bought five trucks before they had a single driver. Five. And then it’s, okay, now what? Now we’ve got to go searching for people. I talked to another owner who had four trucks, and two of them were sitting. I asked why. Drivers quit. That’s half the business down. Two trucks sitting like that can put you out of business.

Listen, there’s nothing wrong with owning a truck you don’t drive. I’ve owned equipment. I think it’s a smart thing to do if you’ve got the credit and the foundation in place. What’s wrong is thinking the truck creates the business. Somebody has to find the driver, check the driver, schedule the driver, pay the driver, keep the truck up, invoice the load, collect the money, and pick up the phone when the plan breaks. If that somebody isn’t you, those jobs still need a name, a budget and somebody checking on them.

So this book starts with the work nobody takes a picture of. You’ll write the job before you advertise it. You’ll run the numbers before you promise anybody pay. Then I’m going to teach you how to recruit: your online presence, what I call your Bob Ross, SEO so drivers find you, your state’s employment systems, Indeed, Facebook, truck stops, and how to put AI to work on all of it. You’ll have a way of finding drivers before an empty seat turns into an emergency. And you’ll learn when to stop, because sometimes the best thing that comes out of recruiting is finding out the job doesn’t work at the price you had in mind. It’s a whole lot cheaper to find that out before you’ve signed for the truck.

CHAPTER 01

The equipment-first trap

Owning the truck doesn’t give you the people, the freight or the systems to run it.



FICTIONAL AI-GENERATED ILLUSTRATION

Buying feels like progress

A truck's easy to get excited about. You can walk around it, take a picture of it, tell people you bought it. When people first buy a truck, a beautiful new truck and a new trailer, they're all fired up. They don't have a CDL. They're the owner of the equipment. And that excitement normally doesn't last long once they start dealing with a driver.

Recruiting doesn't feel like that. It's calls nobody returns, uncomfortable questions, people you have to turn down, and finding out the job you thought was so attractive isn't. Learning the business feels even less like progress. Nobody claps because you figured out how to calculate empty miles.

So people do the fun part first. They buy the truck and tell themselves they'll sort out the rest quick. Then the payment changes every conversation they have. The question stops being, "Does this make sense?" and turns into, "How fast can somebody get this truck moving?"

Pressure bends your judgment. You'll take a driver who doesn't fit the work. You'll promise pay the freight can't cover. You'll treat a missing paper as something to finish next week. The payment didn't make those mistakes. It just made them a lot harder to say no to.

So before you buy, write down what would make you walk away. A price on insurance over the number you can carry. No real freight. No qualified driver who'll take the actual schedule. Too little cash left after the down payment. Decide that now, while you're still free to.

Find the freight first

I tell people all the time, don't buy a truck until you know where the freight is. Why buy equipment and not know what you're going to haul?

Freight research comes before the driver and before the truck. Where's the freight? How do you find it? Where's your driver going to be, and does the freight run back and forth from there? That's why I talk about it so much. There's no rush on it. Take months if you've got the time. Once you've found good paying freight, then it makes sense to ask, why not put it in the back of one of my own trucks?

Here's why that matters in a book about drivers. The freight decides the job. The job decides who'll want it. If you don't know the freight, you can't tell a driver when they'll be home, and that's the first thing a good driver's going to ask you.

Know who does what

Owning equipment and running a motor carrier are two different jobs. If you plan to lease your truck on to an established carrier, learn that carrier's requirements and read the written deal before you buy. If you plan to run your own authority, that's your federal permission to haul for hire, learn what you're taking on. Don't bounce from one to the other because the first plan got hard.

A dispatcher can help find work. A recruiter can introduce you to people. A shop can fix the truck. None of them are responsible for your whole business just because you hired them.

So make a list. Hiring. Driver files. Insurance. Maintenance. Payroll. Dispatch. Safety. Billing. Collections. Emergencies. Put one name next to each one. A vendor can do the work, but you still need to know what got done, where the proof is and what's still open.

If you can't name who answers the driver at two in the morning, you haven't finished designing the company. And if every name on that list is yours, count that time. Your time isn't free just because the business hasn't started paying you.

Meet Wes

Wes is made up. He's what I hear on the phone a lot. Wes doesn't have a CDL. He has some savings and a good job, and he buys a sleeper tractor because the monthly payment looks manageable. He plans to hire a regional driver and pay a dispatcher to find loads.

The truck shows up. The first driver who calls wants to be home every night. The second one wants a guaranteed weekly check Wes hasn't budgeted. The third one's insurance comes back no.

Now look what Wes really has. The job was never defined. The pay was never tested against the freight. And he found out what the insurance company wanted after he'd already bought the truck. Running the same vague ad in more places won't fix any of that.

What should he have done? Described the operation first. Asked an insurance agent. Modeled a week of work. Talked to drivers about that exact job. He might still have bought a truck. It might have been a different truck, for different work, at a different time.

The truck should serve a business that works. You don't build a business around a truck you've already got to pay for.

“Passive income” needs a hard look

In August 2024 the Federal Trade Commission and the state of Florida went after a company called RivX over trucking investment promises. The FTC said people were told they could pay $75,000 or more, have a truck bought in their name and collect monthly income from an operation somebody else ran. In January 2026 a federal court permanently shut that business down. I’m not telling you that applies to everybody who manages trucks.

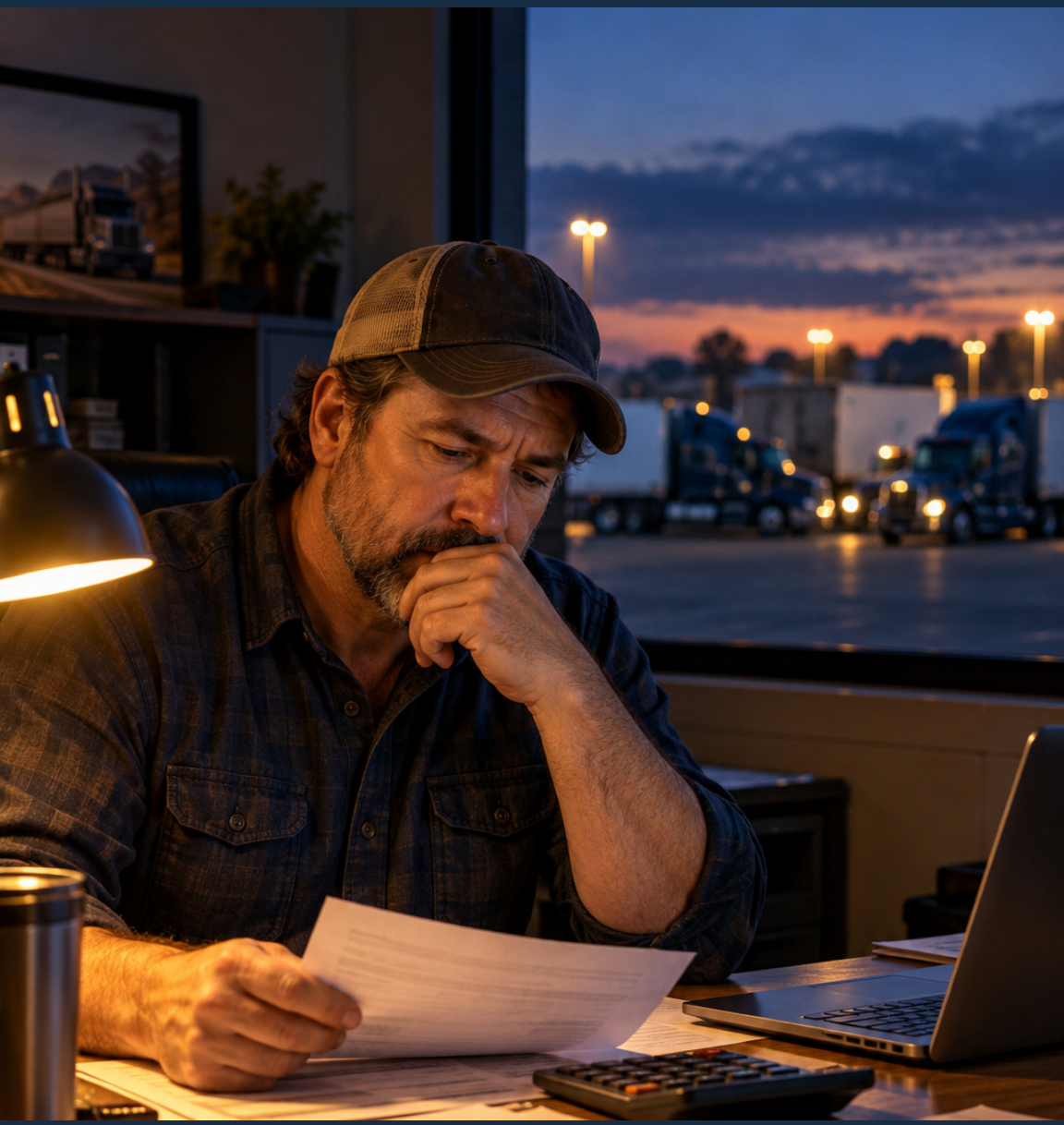
I run a managed truck program myself, so I’ll say this straight. If anybody offers to run a truck for you, me included, you ask the same questions. How’s the revenue documented? Who approves the expenses? Whose name is on the title? Who hires the driver? What insurance applies? How do you see the actual records? And you ask what happens with the driver, because a driver’s a two-person deal, you and that driver, and nobody else can promise that part for you. Anybody who guarantees you a driver or a monthly check is telling you something nobody can promise. A projected number on a sheet is no substitute for those answers.

> **Before you buy equipment, show that you understand the job that equipment has to do and the people who have to do it.**

CHAPTER 02

Read the numbers honestly

This is serious enough without exaggerating it.



FICTIONAL AI-GENERATED ILLUSTRATION

What the failure number actually says

You've heard big failure numbers in this business. I've quoted them myself. So let's be careful with them.

On August 24, 2026, FreightWaves ran a report that attributed an 85% average three-year failure rate to Kirk Mann of Mitsubishi HC Capital. That number was about motor carriers with fewer than two years of operating experience and their own authority, during this long downturn. That's a reported observation about one group in one stretch of time. The report's short, and it doesn't lay out enough of the method for you to treat it as your odds of failing.

It also doesn't say buying before recruiting caused those failures. Financing, freight rates, repairs, cash and management all play into each other. So I'm using it as a reason to be careful. It isn't proof that 85 or 90 percent of all new carriers fail within two years, and I won't teach it to you that way.

Same goes for authority counts. An authority getting revoked isn't automatically a bankruptcy. A company can close on purpose, change its structure, stop running or lose its registration for some other reason. Don't stack numbers with different meanings to make a scarier number.

Here's the question that's actually useful. What would make your company run out of cash, lose its driver or get stopped from operating? You answer that with your own numbers and your own papers. No national percentage can do it for you.

Use benchmarks as questions

The American Transportation Research Institute, ATRI, puts out a yearly report on what it costs to run a truck. Its 2026 update put the 2025 average at $2.336 per mile, up 3.4% from the year before. That's a dated average across a lot of fleets. It isn't a quote for your truck. It's useful because it shows you why a fuel-and-payment estimate on a napkin isn't a plan.

Your costs depend on your truck, your insurance, your freight, your driver pay, where you run and how you bought the truck. A paid-off truck still breaks and still wears out. A cheap truck can come with expensive downtime.

So use the benchmark to find what you left out. If your number's way under it, ask yourself why. Did you count your own labor? Empty miles? Tolls? Money set aside for repairs? If your number's higher, go find out why before you assume customers will pay the difference.

The numbers in this book are made up to teach with. They aren't ATRI's tables.

A loan isn’t a business plan

Getting approved tells you a lender’s willing to lend. It doesn’t tell you the freight, the driver, the insurance and the costs will leave any money.

So don’t admire your best week. Break it. Take away some loaded miles. Add empty miles. Pay late. Add a repair. Take the driver away for a few weeks. Now look at the lowest your bank account gets. If one ordinary bad week means you miss payroll or skip maintenance, the plan’s too fragile to launch.

And don’t count on selling the truck to save you. Truck values move and sales take time. Get a real payoff number and a real sale estimate. What happens if you default depends on your contract and your state, so I’m not going to hand you some standard repossession countdown. Read your agreement before you sign, and get help with what you don’t understand.

Your paperwork is only the start

FMCSA, the Federal Motor Carrier Safety Administration, lists a $300 fee for each type of operating authority. That’s the application fee. It’s the price of asking, and it doesn’t make you ready.

New carriers also get watched. FMCSA describes an 18-month monitoring period, with a safety audit generally inside the first 12 months for the kind of carrier we’re talking about here. Fail that audit and there’s a process and a chance to fix things, so don’t let anybody tell you it’s instant permanent revocation in every case. But your records have to be right from day one.

A license is not a business. A deal is. “I sent in the forms” isn’t your standard. Your standard is, “I can show you how we stay compliant, who keeps the records, and how the bills get paid.”

Your evidence rule

For every number you’re counting on, write down where it came from and the date. A written insurance quote for insurance. A proposed agreement for financing. Real lane information for freight. Actual conversations with drivers for recruiting. Mark a guess as a guess. If you can’t say where a number came from, don’t use it to justify buying a truck.

CHAPTER 03

Invest in knowledge first

Know enough to spot a bad decision before you've signed for it.



FICTIONAL AI-GENERATED ILLUSTRATION

Learn with something to show for it

Reading's only useful if it changes what you decide. So build your preparation around things you can actually produce: a cost model, a cash forecast, a one-page job description, a list of insurance questions, a calendar of who does what for compliance. That's worth more than saying you watched ten videos.

Start at Freight University, freightuniversity.online, and use the official government sources in the back of this book.

Here's the test. Explain each piece out loud to somebody. What costs keep running when the truck stops? How does the driver get paid? What makes a load lose money? Who can say a truck is cleared to go? What happens if the customer pays late? If your answer turns into "the dispatcher handles it," keep learning.

You don't have to become your own attorney, accountant, mechanic and insurance agent. You have to know enough to ask them good questions and understand what they tell you. The more you know, the more valuable you are, even to yourself.

Count every mile

Let's do Wes's math. He's looking at a month with 8,000 loaded miles and 2,000 empty miles. Empty miles, deadhead, are the miles the truck runs with no freight in the trailer. So that's 10,000 total miles.

In this practice model, it costs $1.60 for every mile the truck turns. That's $0.65 driver pay, $0.05 payroll taxes, $0.55 fuel, $0.25 set aside for repairs, $0.05 tires, and $0.05 tolls and everything else. And there's $4,800 a month that gets paid no matter what: $3,000 truck and trailer payments, $1,200 insurance, $300 parking and $300 other.

10,000 miles times $1.60 is $16,000. Add $4,800. That's $20,800 going out for the month.

Divide that by all the miles and it's $2.08 per mile. Divide it by only the loaded miles, since those are the ones that get paid, and it's $2.60. That's what every loaded mile has to bring in just to cover the bills.

Now Wes's buddy tells him the going rate's about $2.40 a loaded mile. 8,000 times $2.40 is $19,200. Wes is $1,600 short, every month, before he's paid himself anything.

So what changes it? The freight. Same truck, same 10,000 miles, but say Wes knows his lanes and only runs 1,000 miles empty. Now it's 9,000 loaded miles at $2.40, which is $21,600. He's $800 ahead. That's why I never stop talking about freight research. That's a $2,400 swing and nobody bought a thing.

Watch out for the common mistake. If you take $2.40 and subtract $2.08 and call it 32 cents profit on every loaded mile, you've mixed two different kinds of miles and fooled yourself.

And read what's in the rate. Fuel surcharge, detention, stop pay, factoring charges and deductions all change it. A detention request you sent in isn't money you've collected.

Cash and profit aren't the same

That math is a cash plan. Your loan principal is cash going out, but your accountant won't treat it as an expense the same way. Depreciation is an accounting entry, and no check gets written for it that day. Have your accountant keep both views for you.

Cash tells you whether you can pay what's due on time. Profit tells you whether the whole thing's worth doing. Don't count the full loan payment and depreciation together without knowing what you're doing, because that double counts part of the truck. And don't ignore replacing the truck just because it's paid off.

Same with you. If you're recruiting, dispatching, fixing pay problems and chasing money for free, the business might just be buying your labor cheap. Put a real number in your long-term plan for what you're worth.

Plan for the gap before you get paid

The truck starts running today. The first real money might come weeks from now. Say $4,900 a week is going out, and it's six weeks before you see the first usable customer payment. That's $29,400 you need just to get across, before startup costs and before anything goes wrong.

Six weeks is a practice number. Your real one comes from your payment terms, your factoring deal if you've got one, and how clean your paperwork is. An invoice with no proof of delivery can sit a long time.

Keep a simple forecast, week by week: cash you start with, money coming in, payroll, fuel, repairs, fixed bills, cash you end with. The lowest ending balance matters more than the month's total. A month can look profitable and still have a payroll crisis in the middle of it.

And keep your piles separate. The money set aside for a repair can't also be the insurance down payment and the recruiting budget. One dollar can't cover three problems.

Talk to your insurance agent early

Your insurance is going to be built around your driver. I've taught this for years. In my experience, when you find your first driver, your primary auto liability price follows that person's driving record. Insurers look at other things too, so ask your agent. You can have a 2007 truck or a 2020 truck. Comp and collision aside, the year of the truck doesn't change that liability number much. The driver does. That's why I want at least two years of experience.

So go to your agent before you shop for a truck. Tell them the actual plan: equipment, freight, where you'll run, your authority status, your experience, what kind of drivers. Ask what would make a driver unacceptable. Ask what they need to approve one. Ask whether changing the driver changes the quote.

Get it in writing: coverage, limits, deductibles, exclusions, payment schedule, dates. The federal minimum to get a carrier's authority active is $750,000 in primary liability for regular freight, and what you truly want is a million, plus cargo coverage. Ask whether your customers or the carrier you're leasing to want more. A quick estimate on the phone isn't coverage for the truck, driver and job you end up with.

This is how you write fair, job-related hiring standards without wasting anybody's time. And keep these three things separate in your head and on paper: what the law requires, what your insurance company requires, and what you personally prefer. Don't advertise a guess about your insurer as if it were federal law.

Learn the driver's clock before you schedule

FMCSA's summary of the hours-of-service rules for freight gives you up to 11 hours of driving after 10 hours off duty, inside a 14-hour window, with 60 and 70-hour limits over 7 and 8 days. There's a break rule and there are exceptions too. Those limits don't mean every route gets every hour. There's loading, inspections, traffic, parking, weather and getting home.

A rate that only works if the driver ignores the clock doesn't work.

Here's your checkpoint. Write out one real week, every mile and every hour of it. Then explain how the driver gets paid, how the bills get paid and how the driver gets home.

CHAPTER 04

The driver reality and the empty seat

The only driver market that counts is the people willing and qualified to do your actual job.



FICTIONAL AI-GENERATED ILLUSTRATION

Drivers aren’t a line item

You’ve got to understand what it’s like to work with truck drivers. I’ve been dealing with them my whole career, and I’ll tell you the truth: drivers are always going to be the roadblock for any trucking company trying to grow. Almost every driver leaves. They go from one truck to another truck to another truck. There are so many jobs out there for them that everybody wants them, and they know it.

Now, I’m not saying drivers are bad. It might sound like it. There are good drivers, business-minded drivers, people who get what we’re trying to do. But think about what we’re doing here. We’re putting hundreds of thousands of dollars into equipment and then handing it to somebody we don’t know. So finding the right person isn’t a small item on your list.

Stop asking if drivers exist

There may be plenty of CDL holders in your area and only a few who want your schedule, meet your requirements, live close enough and will take your pay. That’s your real market.

So define the job first. Local, regional and over-the-road are three different lives. A driver who gets back to the yard at midnight isn’t home the same way as one who finishes every afternoon. A five-day trip with no clear return isn’t the same as a steady weekly route.

Ask what they need. Some want steady money. Some need a certain schedule. Some want a certain kind of truck or freight. A qualified driver can turn down a job that doesn’t fit their life, and that’s fine. You’re not trying to talk everybody into it. You’re looking for a few people whose needs match work you can honestly give them.

What waiting really costs

Let’s put a number on the empty seat. Wes’s truck is parked. His payments are $3,000 a month, insurance is $1,200, parking’s $300 and other bills are $300. That’s $4,800 a month. On a 30-day month, that’s $160 a day.

Ten days costs him $1,600. Twenty-one days, $3,360. Thirty days, $4,800. That doesn’t count repairs, recruiting or anything else.

Don’t cancel or cut your insurance on your own just because the truck’s parked. Talk to your agent and your lender. And parking it doesn’t stop the loan.

Now you know what delay costs in cash. Here’s what that number doesn’t tell you. It doesn’t tell you a bad hire would be cheaper. A rushed hire can cost you a whole lot more than $160 a day.

Lost revenue isn’t lost profit

Here’s where people scare themselves. Take a day Wes could have run on his plan: 450 miles, 360 of them loaded, at $2.40. That’s $864 coming in. Running that day costs $720 at $1.60 a mile. So the day was worth $144 toward his fixed bills and any profit.

If the truck sits, Wes didn’t lose $864. He lost the $144 he would’ve made, and his $160 in fixed bills is coming due either way.

Notice what those numbers are saying. On a day he runs, Wes is still $16 short of that day’s fixed bills. On a day he sits, he’s short the whole $160. The difference between the two is $144. And if there was no load to run that day, even the $144 is a guess.

Don’t add the $160 to the $864 and call it what you’re losing every day. When you’re feeling the pressure is when you need honest numbers the most, because scared numbers will push you into a bad hire or a bad vendor deal.

A pipeline has stages

An inquiry is somebody who responded. A contacted prospect is somebody you actually talked to. A basic fit is somebody who appears to fit the job. An applicant has given you the formal application. A candidate in qualification still has checks or approvals open. A driver released for dispatch has passed everything your company requires.

Those are different things. Twenty messages aren’t twenty drivers. Two good conversations aren’t two hires. Keep the stage and the next step next to every name so hope can’t hide unfinished work.

Try to have one strong candidate and a backup who’s agreed you can keep them posted before you make a truck commitment you can’t undo, as far as timing allows. That’s my recommendation. It isn’t a law, and it doesn’t mean anybody will wait for you. And never ask somebody to quit their job for a launch that’s still a maybe.

Test the job before you buy

Run a real test. Two weeks, a set budget, a review date. Tell people plainly if you’re getting ready to launch and when you honestly expect it. Follow each platform’s rules, and don’t advertise a job as open today when it isn’t.

Then sit down and look. How many people did you reach? How many fit? Why did the others say no? What’s still unknown? If good people keep turning down the schedule or the pay, change the plan before that truck payment turns real.

CHAPTER 05

Recruiting is a skill you never stop using

If you own a truck, run a trucking company or help build one, this is part of your job.



FICTIONAL AI-GENERATED ILLUSTRATION

Always be looking for a great driver

Let me say this as plainly as I can. Recruiting drivers is a skill, and it's a must. It's what keeps the equipment moving. A truck with no driver is a payment. I'm hunting drivers every day, and I've been doing it for years, because the day you need one is the worst day to start looking.

Most people treat recruiting like a fire drill. A driver quits, the truck parks, the owner panics and runs an ad. I want you to run it like freight research: a little every week, whether you've got an empty seat or not. Whoever can attract drivers wins this business. I talked to an investor who had four Peterbilts. Three of them weren't moving, and within a week she lost another driver. She was paying more than $2,000 a month in finance charges. She asked me what she could do. Her trucks were beautiful. What she'd never built was a way for drivers to find her.

So here's the whole system, and the next chapters teach each piece:

1. Write the real job.
2. Paint your Bob Ross, so there's a picture of your company online.
3. Get found, so a driver searching in your state lands on you.
4. Go where drivers are filling out applications.
5. Put AI to work on the busywork, with you still making the decisions.
6. Answer fast, track everybody, and look at it every week.

You need a reason

I'm hunting drivers every day, but I've got to have a reason. What am I looking for? Someone to work in this specific industry and do this specific thing.

Trucking companies are ordinary. There are tens of thousands of them starting up. What's the difference between you and John Smith Trucking? Why would a good driver leave where they are and come to you? Having a purpose behind your company is how you stand out, and it gives your drivers a reason to stay. When your purpose is real, you become attractive to drivers. Take a minute and invoke your thinking on that, because you're going to need it for your Bob Ross.

Part of your reason is the truck. If you've got good equipment, market it. Part of it is the freight. One flyer I've seen work just says, "I got freight, I'm looking for a professional driver." Drivers are going to want to know what's going on. It may take a week and it may take a month. That's what it takes.

Know your stuff when they call

A driver can tell in about a minute whether you know what you're talking about. I talked with a driver one time who was very leery of me. He'd been in the business almost twice as long as I had. He started talking about pallets, and I knew which pallets he meant. By the end of the call it was, "All right, let's do this." That's why I tell you to be a professional with one particular piece of equipment and one area of freight. When you know it, drivers can hear it.

Look where you are first

I grew up in a small farming town. Everybody knew everybody, and there were a lot of truck drivers around. So when somebody tells me they're building a trucking company, I say, why not look where you are?

Interviews with strangers are hard. I've been doing them for over 25 years. You can put anybody on the phone with me, they can say anything in the world, and I still don't have a clue who that person is. A local driver's different. If I hire a driver out of California and I'm down in the backwoods of Georgia, how do I hold that person accountable? If they're local, I can sit across from them and say, listen, here's my business plan. I'm not asking you to just be a driver. Here's how we can grow this together.

And I'm looking for at least two years' experience with a clean driving record. Less than that's going to affect your insurance, and somebody with a couple of years has been out there. They know the ups and downs. That's my preference, and your insurance company may set its own, so keep both separate from the law.

Recruiting as a service

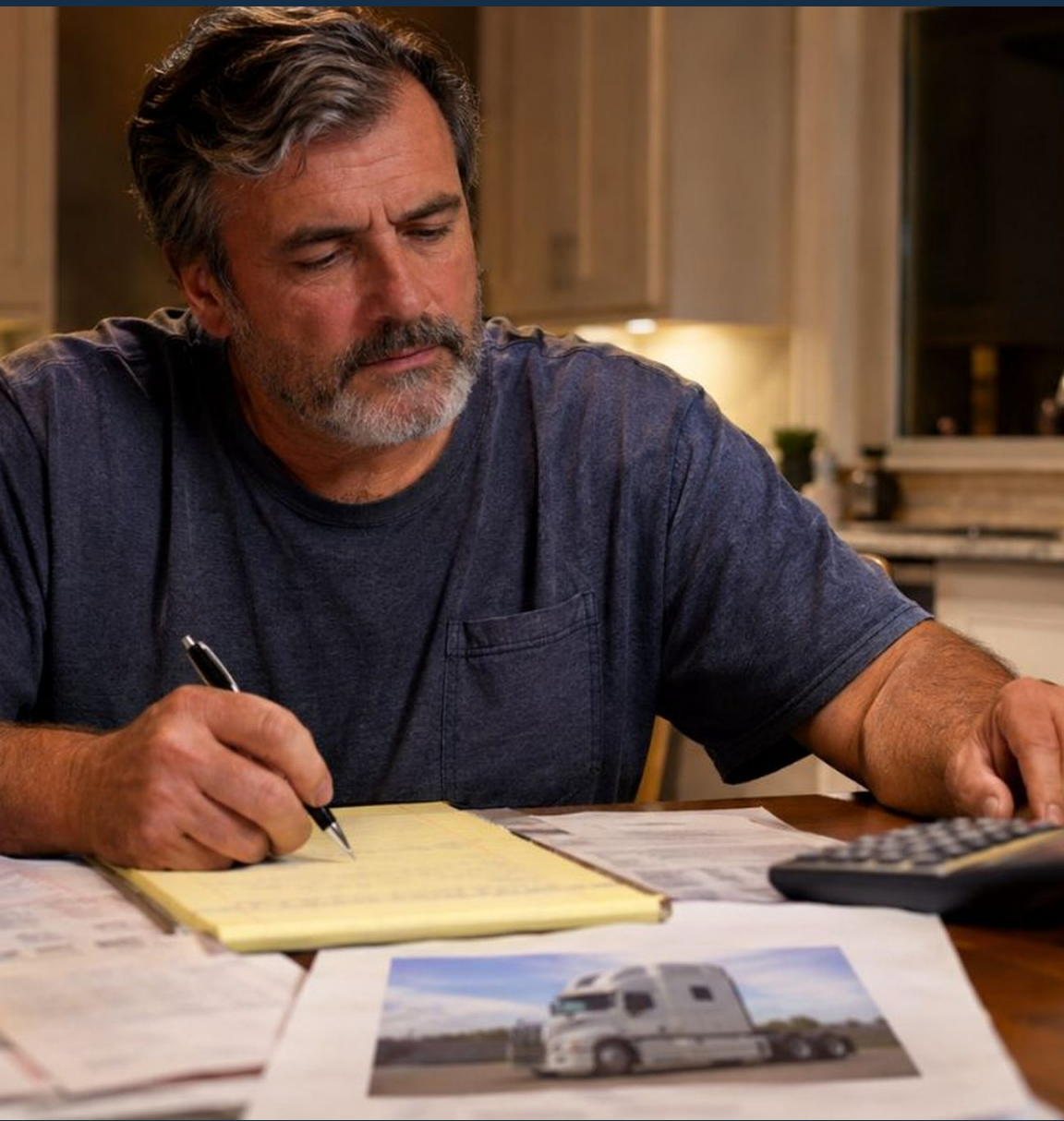
If you're a dispatcher or a Professional Logistics Service Provider helping trucking companies grow, drivers are one of the most valuable things you can bring them. In my experience a very good driver found for a trucking company can be worth a real fee. That's a deal you make with the carrier, in writing. It's separate from any broker authority. A driver isn't a load, and you're not licensed to broker human beings. Some states regulate employment agencies and recruiters, so check yours before you charge for this.

Campaigns are how you do it. Each service you offer gets its own campaign, and "always looking for great drivers" is one of them.

CHAPTER 06

Write the real job

You can’t recruit for a job you haven’t described.



FICTIONAL AI-GENERATED ILLUSTRATION

The one-page job brief

Before you write an ad, write one page. Home base. Freight and equipment. Where they'll run. The schedule. How home time works. How pay works. The benefits you actually offer. The qualifications that matter. Whether they touch freight, stay out overnight, work weekends or do anything special.

Do the math on the pay. If it's per mile, say which mileage system you use and whether empty miles get paid. If it's a percentage, say a percentage of what, and what's left out. If you show a weekly range, say what it assumes and whether any of it's guaranteed. Have the final wording checked against pay-transparency and wage rules where you are.

Why bother? Look at what drivers say. One 2026 survey from recruiting firms put home time and predictable or higher pay at the top of the reasons drivers look around. That isn't a scientific study, but it matches what I hear on the phone every week.

An honest brief may bring you fewer calls than a big promise. Good. The wrong calls eat your time and hide the reasons the right people said no.

A sample ad

This one's made up. Change every detail to what's true for you.

> **Class A regional dry van driver, Memphis base.** Regional work, overnight trips during the week, home weekends. We're getting ready to add a second truck, expected in November, and we'll confirm the start date before anybody commits. Example pay: $0.65 per dispatched mile, loaded and empty, on the mileage system we'll show you. At 2,300 miles that's $1,495 before taxes. Miles and weekly pay aren't guaranteed. We'll give you detention, layover, benefits and the rest in writing. Call Rosa at the number below, or use the short form on our page, for the full job description and how we qualify drivers.

See what that does? It brings the hard questions into the open. What's the mileage system? What happens in a slow week? What's paid during orientation? Can Rosa really get the driver home every weekend? You need true answers before it runs.

Stay away from "up to" pay that only the best week ever could produce. The driver shouldn't find out the real job after quitting another one. And don't use a photo to make it look like you own a truck you don't. Show your real truck when you've got one, or label the picture as an illustration.

Words that get you in trouble

Federal law bars job ads that show a preference based on race, color, religion, sex, national origin or age 40 and over. So no “young,” no “recent graduate,” no “native speaker,” no “family man.” If you want newer drivers, say, “New CDL holders welcome,” and check with your insurance first. The federal rule says an interstate driver has to be at least 21, so you can state that. Beyond that, keep age out of it.

The federal rule says a commercial driver has to read and speak English well enough to talk with the public, understand road signs, answer an officer’s questions and fill out reports. If you state that, use the rule’s words, check everybody the same way, and keep accents and where somebody’s from out of it. Have an employment attorney look over your standard ad once. It’s cheap compared to the alternative.

CHAPTER 07

Paint your Bob Ross

A picture of your company that’s up there working while you sleep.



FICTIONAL AI-GENERATED ILLUSTRATION

What I mean by Bob Ross

If you've ever watched Bob Ross on television, he painted a whole picture, a little at a time, and people trusted him because they watched him do it. That's what I want you to do with your company. I've been teaching this for years. I've called it your menu, your painting, your Bob Ross. It's who you are in this business, out there where people can find it.

Trucking has become a virtual business. Most of the people you work with will never meet you. Without the internet, without being able to connect in that virtual world, we're dead in the water. The old days of phone books and yellow pages are gone. A driver who hears your name is going to look you up before they call. They've been burned. There are too many sharks out there. So what do they find?

Without marketing, you might live. Without that virtual presence, you won't grow. You want what I call a net, so when a driver's out there in your area looking, you've caught them. I get phone calls because I painted my little Bob Ross years ago. A truck driver in some area searches, I pop up, and my phone rings.

Start with one page

Do you need a big website? No. What you do need is a landing page. One good page where you put your menu.

Go get a domain. Mine have cost around $25. I'm always shopping for them. It can be your company name, and for a campaign it can be something like best dry van drivers in your city. Then set up a simple page. Wix and plenty of others will do it, and you don't have to be a programmer.

Here's what goes on your driver page:

- **Your name**, the same one on your registration, everywhere you show up.
- **Who you are and your purpose**, in plain words. Why should a driver want to drive for you?
- **The freight and equipment**, in plain terms. "53-foot dry van, regional out of Memphis."
- **The real job**, from your job brief, with pay and home time right there.
- **Real pictures** of your real truck and real people, when you've got them. Label anything else as an illustration.
- **Your authority information**, your MC and USDOT numbers, so a careful driver can check you on FMCSA's public site.
- **One easy way to reach you.** A phone number a person can read, and a short form that works on a phone: name, phone, years driving, a good time to call, and an unchecked box if they're okay with texts about the job. Don't make anybody

create a login. The form starts the conversation. The formal application comes later.

- **Your email at your own web address.** A free email account makes you look like a person with a phone.

And every word of it has to be true. Don't show a fleet you don't have, don't promise pay you can't back up, and don't advertise a job that isn't open. If you're also a broker, there's a federal rule on how you show yourself: 49 CFR 371.7. You advertise under your registered name, you say you're a broker, and you don't present yourself as a carrier.

Google Business Profile

This one's free, and it's how you show up on the map when somebody in your area searches. Fill it out all the way and keep it current.

Pay attention to Google's rule, though. It has to be a real location. Google says P.O. boxes and mailboxes at remote locations aren't acceptable, and a rented mailing address where you don't actually operate doesn't qualify. If you run from your home or a yard and don't want your address public, there's a way to show as a service-area business. Google's guidance says the area shouldn't go much past about two hours' drive. Be honest with it.

Ask real drivers and customers for reviews, and answer every one. Don't fake them. The Federal Trade Commission has a rule against fake reviews, including ones written by AI, and against paying for good ones.

Keep painting

One social channel to start. The one you'll actually keep up with. Post a real picture of the truck, a lane you run, a driver you're proud of with their permission, a tip about a pre-trip. Once a week is fine. Three or four times is better.

Join groups in your industry. If you're in dry van, what a lot of us call dry box, get in those groups. Every now and then, throw out "Always looking for a great driver." You can make a clean flyer or graphic in Canva in ten minutes. Then that same picture goes on your page, in your group, on your flyer and in your email signature. Same name, same message, a little at a time.

Start before you're ready. This stuff takes time to show up. What you put up today might bring you a driver months from now. And your Bob Ross doesn't prove you're competent or guarantee anybody a call. It just makes sure that when somebody's looking, they can find you and see who you are.

CHAPTER 08

Get found

SEO means a driver searching in your state lands on you.



FICTIONAL AI-GENERATED ILLUSTRATION

What SEO is

Search engine optimization, SEO, just means setting up your page so the search engines understand what it's about and show it to the right person. I've been working in this for 20 years, and it's a whole training on its own. But you can get the basics done in an afternoon.

Picture it. A great driver in Alabama's tired of the company they're with. They start looking for trucking companies in Alabama. You pop up. That's what you're after. It happens over time, and you can't overlook it. I get contacted by shippers who found me this way too, so the same work pays twice.

Pick your words

Think like the driver. What would they type? Not "logistics solutions." They'd type "dry van driver jobs Memphis" or "regional CDL A jobs home weekends Tennessee."

Your words are three things put together: **the kind of driver**, **the kind of freight or equipment**, and **the place**. Use your city and your state. If your trucking company's down in Alabama and you're in dry van, then Alabama and dry van belong on that page. Own your state before you try to own the country.

Where the words go

- **The page title.** Each page gets one clear title. "Class A Dry Van Driver Jobs in Memphis, TN | Cedar Ridge Transport."
- **The description.** A sentence or two that shows up under your title in search results. Make somebody want to click. "Regional dry van work out of Memphis. Home weekends. Pay and home time spelled out before you call."
- **The main heading on the page**, and naturally through the text. Write it for a person.
- **Your pictures.** Name them and describe them in plain words.
- **One page per job.** Don't cram everything together.

I've taught meta tags for years, so let me give you the update. Google says flat out that it doesn't use the keywords meta tag anymore. Your title and description still matter, and what matters most is real, useful content. Don't stuff the same phrase in fifty times. Google doesn't like it, and neither do drivers.

Get your job into Google's job listings

Here's one most small carriers don't know about. Google has a jobs section in its search results, and you can get your own job into it for free by adding a little bit of code to your job page. It's called JobPosting structured data. You need the date posted, the description, your company name, the location and the title, and you should add the pay and an expiration date too.

If you're on Wix, its SEO settings let you paste in structured data on a page. Test it. Google's Rich Results Test will tell you if it reads right. Google doesn't promise to show it.

The rules are strict, and they're the same rules I'd give you anyway. There has to be a real way to apply on that page, with the details showing without a login. A phone number alone won't do it, so that's your short form. No fake jobs. No false locations. No collecting information for a job that doesn't exist. So if you're still getting ready to launch, your page can tell the truth about that, but the job listing code waits. Keep it saved, and put it up only when the seat's real and open. Take the job down when it's filled.

Give it time

Google says changes can take anywhere from a few hours to several months to show up, and to wait a few weeks before judging. So start now. Don't buy "100 backlinks for $50." Earn links honestly: your local trucking association, your city's business listings, a shop you work with. If you're running equipment, your state's trucking association is a good place to start.

Check it once a month. Search your own words from a phone. Ask every driver who calls, "How'd you find us?" and write it down. Google Search Console is free and shows you what people typed to find you.

CHAPTER 09

Go where drivers are filling out applications

They’re already looking. Go stand where they’re looking.



FICTIONAL AI-GENERATED ILLUSTRATION

As of 2026, I don't know of one good independent study ranking where drivers look, and don't believe anybody who says they've got the final answer. Most of the numbers come from companies selling recruiting. What drivers themselves name is about what I've seen for years: Indeed, trucking forums and boards, Craigslist, Facebook, and word of mouth. So you test, you ask and you write it down.

For your first test, pick one broad job board, one state or public route, and one that's built on relationships. That's enough to learn something without scattering a small budget all over.

Your state has a system. Use it.

This is the one people skip, and it's sitting right there. Every state has a job bank. CareerOneStop, which the U.S. Department of Labor sponsors, lists all 50 states. In Tennessee it's Jobs4TN. You register as an employer and post a job order. Mississippi runs one through its Department of Employment Security, and Arkansas has Arkansas JobLink. Find yours, register your company and post the real job. Ask if there's any cost. Arkansas says plainly that it's free.

Then pick up the phone. Every area has American Job Centers, and they have business teams. Call them. The help line is 1-877-872-5627. Ask three things:

1. Can you send me qualified CDL drivers looking for work around here?
2. Do you run hiring events I can come to?
3. Do you have an on-the-job training program I'd qualify for?

That last one could put money back in your pocket. Under a federal workforce law, WIOA, on-the-job training can reimburse an employer for part of a new hire's wages while they're learning. It's typically up to 50%, and it can go to 75%, and being a small business can help. States run it differently. The big catch is you've got to talk to them first. In Alabama, for example, the trainee can't start until the agreement's approved. So don't hire somebody and then ask. It isn't free drivers, and not everybody qualifies.

Tell them the actual job. Asking for "anybody with a CDL" won't get you far.

Veterans

Veterans have already been trained to run heavy equipment and follow procedure, and a lot of them are looking for what comes next. American Job Centers have staff who work with employers on hiring veterans. Ask for them. The Military Skills Test Waiver lets qualified service members skip the CDL skills test, and DOT's been changing these programs, so check FMCSA's current page. SkillBridge lets service members in their last months of service train with an approved employer while the Defense Department keeps paying them, though getting approved takes work and it's a better fit once you've got some size.

There used to be a federal tax credit for hiring veterans and certain others, the Work Opportunity Tax Credit. It expired at the end of 2025, and as of May 2026 it hadn't been renewed. Ask your accountant before you count on it.

Indeed

Indeed's a real place drivers look, and you can start for free. Its page says you can post up to three free jobs a calendar month, live up to 30 days, and they sink as newer ones come in. To stay up top you sponsor them, and its pricing page says budgets start at $5 a day or $150 a month, with minimums that vary by role and location.

How it charges has changed over the years, and Indeed's own pages describe it a couple of ways: per click on some, per started application on others. So read the budget screen on your own job before you agree to anything. Sponsored budgets renew on their own, and the charges only stop when you pause or close the post. Put that on your calendar.

Get your job brief, business name and who's answering ready first. Use three to five screening questions. Indeed's screeners can send somebody to a rejected tab automatically, so check that tab now and then. Decide who reads applications every day.

Watch it while it's running. If people keep misunderstanding home time, fix the description. If qualified people don't answer you, look at when you're calling. If nobody good applies, look at the job before you spend more.

Facebook, and the rest of social

Find groups tied to your home base, your equipment or your kind of work. Read their rules. A lot of them want job posts in one thread and will boot you for posting anywhere else, so ask the administrator. One short, local, specific post beats a vague ad copied into forty groups.

Put the schedule and pay where people can see them, and invite them to talk privately. Never ask for a picture of a CDL, a Social Security number or medical information in a comment thread.

Paid ads have their own rules. Meta treats job ads as a special category with limits on targeting by age, gender and exact location, so it's built to keep you from excluding people. Check Ads Manager for the current limits. Old tutorials are often wrong.

Count real conversations with qualified people. Likes don't count. A post can get a lot of attention because people are arguing on it.

Driver boards, forums and Craigslist

Boards built for CDL drivers can reach people already looking. Compare written prices, contract length, renewal terms and exactly what they deliver. A posting, a list of leads and a placement deal are three different things to buy. The Truckers Report has forums, jobs and company reviews, and drivers talk about carriers there, so read what they say about yours. Craigslist charges for job posts in many areas, around $10 to $75 depending on the city.

Get out from behind the computer

You don't need a massive ad budget to find your next driver. You need to get out there and connect. Go to your local truck stops, fuel stations, CDL schools and distribution centers. Introduce yourself. Be human. Buy a coffee. Buy lunch. Ask questions and listen. You'd be surprised how many professional drivers are tired of broken promises.

Put up that flyer where you've got permission. Truck stops set their own rules. Keep it short: the job, the base, the schedule, how pay works, one phone number a person can read.

Look in your community, too. Local papers, VFW halls, repair shops, tire shops.

Your own drivers are your best source once you've got good ones. I'll show you a referral setup in Chapter 13. One caution from the EEOC: if word of mouth is your only method and it gives you a workforce that all looks alike, that can be a legal problem. So run it alongside the public channels.

CDL schools are only a good partner if you can responsibly hire and develop a new driver. Check with your insurance first. A one-truck owner with no way to train shouldn't treat a school as a shortcut to experience. Remember what I said about two years. And finishing FMCSA's Entry-Level Driver Training doesn't mean somebody's ready for your operation.

Agencies

A recruiting agency can make sense when it solves a specific problem at a price you can justify. Get a written quote, replacement terms, refund terms and a clear answer on who screens what. I'd rather you build your own pipeline, but I'm not saying every agency's a waste.

CHAPTER 10

Put AI to work

It can do the typing. You still make the deal.



FICTIONAL AI-GENERATED ILLUSTRATION

I use AI across my operation every day, so I'm not telling you this from the sidelines. It's a real help to a one-person trucking company. A small owner can now do marketing that used to take a whole office. A recruiting-firm survey in spring 2026 said about one in four drivers had used AI tools in their own job search, so they're using it too.

What it's good for

If you're on LFS AOS, MT can help with a lot of this. Any good AI assistant can do these:

- **Turn your job brief into an ad.** Give it the true facts and ask for a Facebook post, an Indeed description and a flyer, each in plain words.
- **Write your page.** Your landing page, your title and your description, using your words.
- **Find your search words.** "What would a Class A dry van driver in Memphis type when looking for a regional job?"
- **Find your state's systems.** "What's the state job bank in Tennessee, and who do I call at the local American Job Center?" Then go check that it's right.
- **Make your graphics and images.** Label them as illustrations, and don't pass one off as your truck.
- **Build your tracker and weekly review.** A simple sheet with stages and next steps.
- **Practice the call.** Have it play a skeptical driver asking about home time. You'll hear where your answers are weak.
- **Clean up your notes** after a conversation, in factual, job-related language.
- **Spot what's missing.** Paste your ad in and ask, "What would a driver want to know that this doesn't say?"

Here's a prompt to steal:

> Here's my job brief: [paste it]. Write a 100-word Facebook post for a local trucking group. Use only the facts I gave you. Plain words, no hype. Put pay and home time in the first two lines. Don't promise anything that isn't in the brief. Then list any question a driver would ask that my brief doesn't answer.

The rules

You check every fact. AI will make up a pay rate, a benefit or a regulation and sound completely sure of itself. It doesn't know your job. Nothing goes out until you've read it.

A person decides. Don't let a tool rank or reject drivers on its own. The federal government pulled its AI hiring guidance in January 2025, but the discrimination laws never went anywhere, and you're still responsible for what your tool does. States are moving on this. Illinois has a law in effect, Colorado's takes effect January 1, 2027, and New York City requires audits for certain tools. If you buy a tool that scores applicants, talk to an attorney first. A third-party score can also raise background-report questions under the Fair Credit Reporting Act.

Don't feed it private records. No Social Security numbers, medical information, drug test results or Clearinghouse details in an AI tool unless you know exactly how it's secured and you're allowed to. Those stay locked up.

Watch automated calls and texts. The FCC has ruled that AI-generated voices count as artificial under the phone law, the TCPA, so you need prior express consent before an AI voice calls somebody. If the call's advertising or telemarketing, that's prior express written consent, and the call has to say who's calling. Ask your attorney which one fits a recruiting call. Automated texts can fall under the same law. So get a clear opt-in on your form, honor "stop" right away, and when in doubt, have a human being make the call. A real person calling back fast beats a robot anyway.

Don't fake anything. No made-up reviews, no made-up drivers, no jobs that aren't open.

MT can get it wrong too, so you check it. MT prepares the work. You say yes. That's how I run it, and that's how you should too, whichever tool you use.

CHAPTER 11

Answer fast and track everybody

Recruiting’s manageable when every person has a status.



FICTIONAL AI-GENERATED ILLUSTRATION

Answer like the job matters

One big driver screening company's data, from June 2025, showed carriers who answered an application within five minutes reached about a 6.2% hiring rate, against a 3.7% average on its platform. It also showed hiring rates falling as much as half when the hiring cycle ran past ten to fifteen days. That's a vendor's data and a correlation, so don't treat it as a law of nature. But it matches what I've seen. A good driver's got other calls coming.

Set a standard you can keep. Say a personal answer within two business hours during the hours you've posted. That's my suggestion. Have somebody cover you when you can't.

Start simple: "Thanks for calling about the regional job. Is this a safe time to talk, or are you driving? I'd like to explain the schedule and pay, then hear what you're looking for." Never push a driver to read a message, fill out a form or do an interview while they're driving.

After the talk, send the next step the way they prefer. If you don't hear back, follow up a couple of times and stop when they ask you to. Write down that they said you could contact them, and when you last did.

Spend against results

Ask everybody how they found you and write it down. If the same person shows up from two places, count them once and keep both sources in your notes. Otherwise a weak campaign looks better than it is.

Say a made-up campaign costs $300 and brings 30 different people who inquired, 12 conversations, 6 basic fits, 3 applicants and 1 driver who starts. That's $10 per inquiry, $50 per basic fit and $300 in advertising per start. Those are three different numbers. Know which one you're talking about.

Then add screening fees, paid orientation, your own time, travel and any placement fee to get your real cost of hiring. Keep what the empty seat costs in its own column so you don't count it twice. Later on, work out your cost per driver still with you at 90 days, counting only hires who've had time to get there.

Don't crown a winner after one hire. Small numbers lie to you. Compare fit, how quickly they answer, who actually starts and who stays. A place that sends fewer calls may send better ones.

Look at it every week

Once a week, look at your stages. Where are people dropping off? Calls not answered? Expectations wrong? Applications not finished? Qualifications unsettled? Fix that stage. Give every next step one owner and a due date. And keep your Bob Ross going while you're at it. That's the weekly rhythm: post something, check the tracker, make your calls, look at the numbers.

CHAPTER 12

Screen carefully and make the first hire

Somebody being interested is where this starts. It doesn’t clear them to drive.



FICTIONAL AI-GENERATED ILLUSTRATION

Fit and qualified are two different questions

The first conversation tells you whether the work and what they expect look like they match. It doesn't tell you they're legally qualified. Ask about their experience with this equipment and freight, what schedule they need, where they live, when they're available. Explain the job before you ask them to spend time on a formal process.

Ask everybody the same job-related questions. "Tell me how you handle a delivery appointment you can't safely make" tells you more than how friendly they were. Ask for examples: reporting a defect, calling in a delay, sorting out a pay question, planning where to park. The federal application asks for a date of birth, and an interstate driver has to be at least 21. Beyond that, age stays out of your questions.

Listen for judgment. Then check the things that need records. A confident answer doesn't prove a license is valid or that your insurer will take them. A quiet person isn't automatically a bad driver. Keep your notes factual and about the job.

And stay away from health questions in that first conversation. A DOT medical card, DOT being the Department of Transportation, is one thing, and it's part of qualifying a driver. Asking somebody about their health or a disability before you've made an offer is another thing, and federal law limits it. Get help with this one so you do it right.

Use a current application

For drivers covered by the federal rules, 49 CFR 391.21 spells out what the application has to include, including employment history. The extra seven years of commercial driving history doesn't kick in at some certain age, whatever you've read online. Use a current, compliant application.

Decide who checks that it's complete and who follows up on gaps. Tell the applicant how the information gets used, and give them a secure way to send it. A short inquiry form's fine for the first step. It can't replace the application, and a few answers on social media certainly can't.

The records

For covered drivers, you look at license class, endorsements and restrictions, medical qualification, driving record, safety performance history, and a road test or what the rules accept in place of one. Check the current rule for your driver and your operation. A valid CDL can stand in for the road test only if the state's road test was in the kind of truck you'll assign. And know the rule on non-domiciled CDLs, the licenses states issue to people who aren't residents. A tighter federal rule took effect March 16, 2026, and it was challenged in court, so check where it stands today.

Section 391.23 generally requires you to ask each state where the driver held a license in the past three years for their driving record, and to ask their DOT-regulated

employers from the past three years for their safety history. Those two are the ones with a 30-day window from the day they start. Everything else comes first: the application, the license, the medical qualification, and the road test or what's accepted in its place have to be in place before they drive. So do the Clearinghouse query and the drug test I cover below. You can decide to get the records and employer replies done sooner too, and I'd tell you to. Just don't confuse your policy with the wording of the rule.

Keep a driver qualification file with a named person responsible and a renewal calendar. Section 391.51 says what goes in it and how long to keep it, and different papers have different clocks, so don't apply one rule to everything. Put the annual driving record check and the documented annual review on that calendar. For CDL drivers, follow the current process for confirming medical status on the state record. A paper card alone may not finish the file.

For day-to-day management, keep an index: item, source, date, who reviewed it, where it is, next review date. The index points you to the proof. Sensitive records belong behind a lock, and a shared recruiting spreadsheet isn't one.

PSP is an extra tool

FMCSA's Pre-Employment Screening Program, PSP, is voluntary. It shows a driver's safety history for hiring purposes, with their written permission: five years of crashes and three years of inspections. It doesn't replace the driving record, the other required checks or your own judgment. FMCSA's own fact sheet says carriers who used it lowered crash rates by 8% on average and driver out-of-service rates by 17%. It's cheap, and I'd pull it on anybody I was serious about.

It isn't a pass or fail, and a crash on it doesn't prove fault. Read it in context. It's a background report, so the Fair Credit Reporting Act steps apply: FMCSA's own form has you give the applicant a copy and a summary of their rights before a final decision against them, or notice within three business days if they applied remotely.

Clearinghouse and drug test are two separate things

If your driver's covered by FMCSA's drug and alcohol rules, you've got to run a pre-employment full query in the Clearinghouse, and the driver gives consent electronically inside the Clearinghouse. Current drivers need at least one query a year. A limited query can do for that, but if it shows anything, you've got 24 hours to run the full one. A driver in prohibited status can't do safety-sensitive work.

A query isn't a drug test. New hires need a pre-employment drug test with a verified negative result back before they drive, unless a specific exception truly applies. Don't assume an old test counts. If the start date slips, check where you stand all over again.

Get a qualified program administrator set up for the ongoing testing program, and keep those results private. Whoever's helping you recruit needs to know whether the person can move forward. They don't need the details behind it.

Be fair, and keep it private

If you use an outside company for background reports, federal law requires a disclosure, written permission, and a process before you turn somebody down because of the report. The Federal Trade Commission explains the basics, there are trucking-specific provisions, and states can add more. Use a real process. Don't make up a rejection text.

Don't collect sensitive information through ordinary texts or public forms. Limit who sees it, use legitimate providers, know how long you keep it and how you get rid of it, and keep applicants off your marketing lists.

When something doesn't line up, ask and verify. When something truly disqualifies somebody, follow your process. Neither one calls for gossip.

Make the offer honestly

Go over the written terms, the expected start date, what checks are still open, the truck and anything else the launch depends on. Say the conditions plainly. I'm not giving you an employment agreement in this book, so use what's right for your state and your business.

If the launch slips, tell them right away. Don't leave a person hanging while you negotiate on a truck. Keep your backup informed, and don't let two people think they've got the same job.

Before anybody gets dispatched, sit down with whoever's responsible for safety and go through it: driver file, testing and query status, insurance acceptance, truck ready, permissions in place, orientation done. Anything open is a hold. A customer waiting on freight doesn't change that.

Teach the real first day

Cover pay examples, how dispatch communicates, reporting hours, reporting defects, what to do in a breakdown, what to do in an accident, the load paperwork, fuel and who to call. Have the driver explain the key steps back to you and show you the systems.

A signature proves something was signed. It doesn't prove they understood it. Walk through a delay, a defect and a pay problem before those happen. They should leave knowing how to get help, and knowing you'll take a safety concern seriously.

CHAPTER 13

Keep the pipeline alive

Keeping a driver starts when the job you deliver matches the job you described.



FICTIONAL AI-GENERATED ILLUSTRATION

Week one is an audit of your promises

A new driver's comparing your ad to your company. Is the truck ready? Can they reach dispatch? Are the miles figured the way you said? Does the first pay statement make sense? Little letdowns can point to something bigger.

Check in after the first trip and after the first payroll. Ask three things. What was different from what we told you? What made the work harder than it needed to be? What do you need an answer on before the next trip? Write it down, and write down who's following through.

Don't promise a repair, a pay fix or a schedule change just to end a hard conversation. Give a real next step and come back to them. You earn trust by finishing what you said you'd do, even the small stuff.

Partners, and keep it business

Treat them like a professional. But let me give you one warning from experience. We don't want to be best friends with our drivers. When it turns into that, they start telling you what to do. I told a driver not long ago, "Man, I think I work for you." A professional relationship is what works. Turn them into coworkers and business people, and leave the best friend stuff out. You'll get along better.

Take care of the basics

Pay that's right. Schedules that work. Trucks that are kept up. People who talk to each other with respect. No recruiting slogan can stand in for those. If you promised predictable home time, build your dispatch decisions around it and be honest about exceptions before they turn into a habit.

Have a way for defects to get reported, acknowledged and closed. The driver should know what's been looked at and what happens next. A safety concern isn't a loyalty test, and you don't pressure anybody to run equipment that should be held for repair. Replace it before it breaks, too. I always talk about preventive maintenance. The airlines fly planes for decades because they replace parts before they fail.

When the freight changes, revisit the job. A driver you hired for regional may not want long over-the-road trips. That's a change to talk about. It isn't a bad attitude. And if you can't deliver the original promise anymore, change your ad too.

Referrals you can afford

Once your drivers trust the operation, ask for referrals. Anybody they send you goes through the same qualification as everybody else. Friendship doesn't waive standards.

Here's how I've taught it. Let your driver earn something real for bringing you the next good driver. As an example, $500 for recruiting your next great driver, and

$200 a month for every month that driver keeps driving for you. Think about what that does. Now your first driver wants the new driver to be happy, because they're both better off. Drivers talk, and I'd rather have them talking about why they stay.

Those amounts are my example, not a market number. Write down who can refer, how you record it, what happens with duplicates, when it's paid and when it stops. Have your accountant look at how it gets paid. Don't leave yourself room to change the deal after it worked. Never make a driver pay a recruiting fee, and don't let anybody hide bad news about the job to get a bonus. And run the math against your actual margin before you offer it.

Stay in touch honestly

Keep a list of people who said they'd welcome hearing from you. Write down what work they want, how to reach them and when you last talked. Stop when they ask.

If there's no opening, say so. Don't run an immediate-start ad just to collect names. People move on, so an old name isn't a ready replacement. When a job opens, check they're still interested and do the whole current qualification process again.

Measure it fairly

In a small fleet, one person leaving can swing your percentages a lot. Write down starts, departures, how long they stayed, the job, where they came from and the reason they gave. Separate them leaving, you letting them go and other circumstances.

For a 90-day number, only count people who've had the time to reach 90 days. If three people started last week, they aren't in it yet. Keep the count next to the percentage so the small sample stays visible.

Look for patterns you can fix. Complaints about pay figures mean look at your pay process. People leaving after route changes mean look at how you designed the job. A new ad won't fix an operating problem.

Plan for a clean goodbye

I've had somebody call me because their driver left a truck at a truck stop, took a ride and quit. It took thousands of dollars to get the truck back and the load was late. So have a process before you need it: returning the truck, keys, devices and records, getting the truck back safely, handling final pay correctly, updating your systems. Do it without threats or made-up deductions.

Ask what could have been better, and don’t make them agree with you. Then learn what you can.

> **A pipeline that’s alive is useful. A company that keeps its promises doesn’t have to spend nearly as much keeping one alive.**

CHAPTER 14

Make the purchase decision

Being ready is proof you can look at, and no deadline can stand in for it.



FICTIONAL AI-GENERATED ILLUSTRATION

Three decisions, not one

Doing this in order doesn't mean every step waits until a driver's fully hired. Some of it has to come together at once. The point is to settle the big unknowns before you take on equipment costs you can't undo.

There are three separate decisions. Does the operation work? Are you prepared enough to commit? Are this specific driver and this specific truck authorized and ready to dispatch? A yes on the first doesn't give you a yes on the other two.

For the first, look at the freight, the all-mile math, the cash and the job. For the second, look at the truck's condition, financing, insurance, what you learned from candidates, timing and your fallback. For the third, confirm everything operational and safety-related is done.

A 30 to 60-day plan

Here's a rhythm I'd suggest. It's no prediction of how fast any agency or hire will move.

Days 1 to 10. Define the business model and the work. Finish your learning outputs. Get early insurance guidance. Figure out who's responsible for registration and safety. Build your first cash forecast.

Days 11 to 25. Test the job with honest recruiting. Track inquiries, conversations, fit and objections. Look at equipment without assuming you have to pick one. Fix your pay and schedule using what you learned.

Days 26 to 40. Move good candidates into the formal process. Line up what the launch needs. Get written information on equipment and financing. Run down any cost you're not sure of. Have your advisers look at the actual plan.

Days 41 to 60. Commit only if the proof's there. Coordinate delivery, coverage, qualification, orientation and first work. If it isn't ready, extend the schedule.

Buy the truck like a business decision

Match the truck to the freight, the routes, parking, who can service it and what the driver has to do. Get a competent, independent inspection and read the maintenance history. Know what the warranty really covers and how you actually get work done under it.

My first truck was a 2007 Freightliner Cascadia. It was used, but I knew that truck, because I'd brokered it and moved freight in it for a couple of years before I bought it. I knew its history. You won't always have that, so inspect harder when you don't. You can run used trucks if you keep up with preventive maintenance. Other people's skipped maintenance is what gets you a $1,000 tow bill on the side of the road. I also tell people to stay with the same kind of truck, so parts and repairs are simpler.

Price the whole thing: down payment, financing, taxes and fees, transport, immediate repairs, tires, required equipment, insurance, and the time before it earns anything. The sticker's one line of that.

Don't spend your repair money on making it look good. And don't assume a truck's ready because it starts and moves.

Give yourself a stop rule

Write down the lowest cash balance you'll launch with, the most unsettled exposure you'll accept, and a date to recheck candidate interest. Use real amounts from your plan. I can't pick them for you.

If your main candidate walks, revisit the decision. If the insurer changes terms, rerun the numbers. If the inspection finds a big repair, change the cost and the timing. Those aren't annoyances to work around. They change the decision.

Strong ad results don't make up for too little cash. A cheap truck doesn't make up for the wrong driver. One failed must-have can be enough to hold the launch.

If you already bought the truck

Start with facts and skip the blame. Where's the truck, what condition is it in, what coverage is on it, when are the payments due, what's it costing to store, how much cash do you have, what have you signed? Name who's responsible for securing and maintaining it while you figure this out.

Then do the work you skipped: the job brief, the insurance review, the cost model, the recruiting test. Keep your qualification standards where they are. Being in a hurry can mean more of your attention. It can't mean skipped checks.

If you see trouble coming, call your lender early. Ask what options exist and get any agreement in writing. Don't assume a friendly phone call changes what you owe. Get real advice on your contract and your ways out.

Lay your options side by side: hold it while you rebuild the plan, lease it on legally to the right operation, sell it, or something else you can document. Look at cost, restrictions, timing and risk. If it has to move, use a qualified, insured provider for that move. Don't dispatch an unqualified applicant just to relocate your truck.

The next truck takes the same test

One good hire doesn't mean the second truck fills itself. More trucks mean more cash on the line and more work for whoever's managing it. Run the same readiness check on every new unit.

Is your current driver getting paid right? Are equipment problems getting closed? Is your tracker current? If the first truck isn't stable, a second one just doubles the

trouble. Grow on a process that repeats, and don’t let the first big deposit talk you into it.

The decision you’re earning

You’re ready to think about a truck when you can explain the work, defend the numbers, name the people, show the preparation and survive a normal bad stretch. You’re ready to dispatch only when the actual requirements are met.

Knowledge first. A real driver pipeline next, and it never stops running. Then equipment, in a launch that’s coordinated and based on proof. Keep that order when the deal looks good, when a seller’s pushing you, and when somebody says the driver will be easy to find.

The truck can wait for a sound decision. Your cash might not survive a bad one.

Worksheet 1 | The job you’re actually offering

Fill this in before you write an ad. If you can’t answer something, that’s a question to go answer.

Business model and who’s the hiring manager

Home base, where they’ll run and what freight

Equipment and any special duties

Normal schedule, overnights and how home time works

Pay method, mileage or revenue basis, and an example calculation

Detention, layover, orientation and other pay terms

Benefits you truly offer, and who qualifies

What’s the law, what’s your insurer, and what’s your preference

Expected start window and what the launch still depends on

Worksheet 2 | Empty-seat cash budget

Only count cash that keeps going out. Keep depreciation and lost contribution separate. Pick a number of days for your month and stick with it.

Monthly truck and trailer payments

Monthly insurance while parked, confirmed with your insurer

Parking, storage and other bills that keep coming

Total monthly cash going out

Days in your planning month, and cash burn per day

Cost of a 10-day vacancy

Cost of a 21-day vacancy

One-time recruiting or repair needs

Reserve you truly have left after other uses

Worksheet 3 | Weekly recruiting review

Keep one row per person in your own tracker, and keep sensitive records in a secure place. This is your summary. It isn’t a driver file.

Review week, who’s responsible, channels used

Spend by channel and total actual charges

People who inquired / people you reached / basic fits

Applications / in qualification / cleared to start

Main reasons good people said no

Oldest open next step, and who owns it

Cost per basic fit and advertising cost per start

What you’ll change next week, and when you’ll review it

Who said you could contact them later

Worksheet 4 | Qualification and dispatch release

Use it with the current rules for your operation and a qualified reviewer. It's a management list, not a complete legal checklist. For each item write where the proof is, who reviewed it and the date.

Application and employment history reviewed

License, endorsements, restrictions and medical qualification

Driving record and safety history checks

Road test or accepted equivalent; ready for this particular job

Clearinghouse full query and drug test

Insurer accepted the driver; coverage in force

Truck ready and permissions in place

Orientation, pay terms, contacts and first assignment

RELEASE or HOLD, who decided, the date and what's open

Worksheet 5 | Before you buy

Mark each one READY, HOLD or DOESN'T APPLY, with a reason. Anything important left open means HOLD. This isn't a points system.

I can explain the business and where the freight comes from.

My all-mile math and cash forecast survive a bad stretch.

I have written insurance guidance for the actual operation.

My recruiting test gave me real proof of candidates who fit.

Candidate timing, qualification steps and alternatives are clear.

I understand the truck's condition and the full cost of buying it.

Registration, coverage, delivery and hiring timing line up.

I'll still have cash reserves after I commit.

The decision, why, who owns it and when we look again.

Conclusion: Build the business before you buy the truck

A driver is a professional choosing a job. A truck is equipment you choose to do work. Your job is to bring the work, the person, the equipment and the money together so it runs safely and keeps paying its bills.

Start with four things. Write the actual job on one page. Build your all-mile cost and your weekly cash forecast. Put your one page up, your Bob Ross, with your state and your freight in the title. Run a measured recruiting test with an honest description and a real person answering the phone. That'll teach you more than another afternoon looking at truck listings.

If the answers are weak, fix the plan. If they're strong, finish the launch work and make the decision with proof in your hand. If you already bought the truck, use the same discipline to get back in control.

Everything we do in this industry is based on a deal. The deal you make with your driver, the deal you make with your shipper, all of it. Your job is to be the information of the freight. Your driver's job is to take the deal and get it delivered. Get those two things right, and the truck's the easy part.

The goal isn't to own a truck. The goal is to build a company worth owning.

Michael Thomas
Founder, Freight University

Sources

Rules and platforms change, so check the current page before you rely on anything here.

FTC, RivX (Aug 2024 and Jan 2026): https://www.ftc.gov/news-events/news/press-releases/2026/01/federal-court-permanently-shuts-down-deceptive-trucking-business-opportunity

FreightWaves, Aug 24, 2026: https://www.freightwaves.com/news/trucking-downturn-why-85-of-new-carriers-didnt-survive

ATRI 2026 update, as reported by Truckers News: https://www.truckersnews.com/news/article/15830055/truckings-operational-costs-reached-new-high-of-2336-per-mile-in-2025

FMCSA hours of service: https://www.fmcsa.dot.gov/regulations/hours-of-service

FMCSA registration changes: https://www.fmcsa.dot.gov/registration/whats-coming

49 CFR 371.7, 382.301, 382.701, 387.9, 391.11, 391.21, 391.23, 391.25, 391.31, 391.33, 391.41, 391.51: https://www.law.cornell.edu/cfr/text/49

FMCSA operating authority fee: https://www.fmcsa.dot.gov/faq/what-cost-obtaining-operating-authority-mcffmx-number

FMCSA new entrant monitoring and audit timing: https://www.fmcsa.dot.gov/sites/fmcsa.dot.gov/files/docs/mission/policy/80286/new-entry-safety-review-report-enclosure-final-april-2017.pdf

FMCSA non-domiciled CDL final rule: https://www.govinfo.gov/content/pkg/FR-2026-02-13/html/2026-02965.htm

FMCSA PSP fact sheet: https://www.psp.fmcsa.dot.gov/pspApi/Documents/MCFacts.pdf

FMCSA PSP disclosure and authorization form: https://www.psp.fmcsa.dot.gov/PspApi/Documents/PSPDisclosureandAuthorizationForm.pdf

FMCSA CDL medical changes: https://www.govinfo.gov/content/pkg/FR-2026-04-14/html/2026-07173.htm

EEOC, Job Applicants and the ADA: https://www.eeoc.gov/laws/guidance/job-applicants-and-ada

EEOC prohibited practices: https://www.eeoc.gov/prohibited-employment-policiespractices

FTC, Using Consumer Reports: https://www.ftc.gov/business-guidance/resources/using-consumer-reports-what-employers-need-know

FTC fake reviews rule: https://www.ftc.gov/news-events/news/press-releases/2024/08/federal-trade-commission-announces-final-rule-banning-fake-reviews-testimonials

CareerOneStop state job banks: https://www.careeronestop.org/JobSearch/FindJobs/state-job-banks.aspx

Jobs4TN: https://www.jobs4tn.gov | Arkansas JobLink: https://arjoblink.arkansas.gov/ | Mississippi: https://www.mdes.ms.gov/employers/post-job-openings

WIOA on-the-job training: 20 CFR 680.700 and 680.730: https://www.law.cornell.edu/cfr/text/20/680.730

Alabama on-the-job training brochure: https://www.labor.alabama.gov/OJT_brochure.pdf

Work Opportunity Tax Credit, Congressional Research Service (May 13, 2026): https://www.everycrsreport.com/files/2026-05-13_R43729_ab1bd03cea785873d6fc358b07e7fde0d2d5254c.html

FMCSA Military Skills Test Waiver: https://www.fmcsa.dot.gov/registration/commercial-drivers-license/application-military-skills-test-waiver

Indeed pricing: https://indeed.com/hire/cs/pricing

Indeed free and sponsored jobs: https://www.indeed.com/hire/resources/howtohub/free-vs-sponsored-jobs-on-indeed

Craigslist posting fees: https://www.craigslist.org/about/help/posting_fees

Meta special ad categories, as explained by Jon Loomer: https://www.jonloomer.com/special-ad-categories-meta-ads/

Google SEO Starter Guide: https://developers.google.com/search/docs/fundamentals/seo-starter-guide

Google JobPosting: https://developers.google.com/search/docs/appearance/structured-data/job-posting

Google Business Profile guidelines: https://support.google.com/business/answer/3038177

Wix structured data:
https://support.wix.com/en/article/adding-structured-data-markup-to-your-sites-pages-2546962

Tenstreet data as reported by DC Velocity:
https://www.dcvelocity.com/editorial/featured/report-speed-is-critical-when-hiring-truck-drivers

Spring 2026 driver survey as reported by The Trucker: https://www.thetrucker.com/trucking-news/business/driver-survey-reveals-rising-turnover-risk-pay-stability-and-more

FCC on AI voices (FCC-24-17): https://docs.fcc.gov/public/attachments/FCC-24-17A1.pdf

47 CFR 64.1200: https://www.law.cornell.edu/cfr/text/47/64.1200

Illinois HB 3773, explained by Foley & Lardner: https://www.foley.com/insights/publications/2025/02/illinois-takes-aim-artificial-intelligence-employment/

Colorado SB 26-189, explained by Proskauer:
https://www.proskauer.com/blog/colorados-ai-law-gets-major-rewrite-what-now-for-employers

Federal AI hiring guidance removed, explained by Cooley: https://www.cooley.com/news/insight/2025/2025-02-21-gone-but-not-forgotten-federal-laws-still-apply-despite-guidance-disappearance-act